

Extension Planning Checklist

The 15 Steps Most Homeowners Skip

PERFECT
— SCAL —

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From: The Extension Survival Guide - An Architect's Honest Handbook for UK Homeowners

Complete every step before committing funds. Each one you skip increases your risk of budget blowouts, delays, and disputes.

BEFORE YOU SPEND ANYTHING

1 Run the extend vs. move calculation

Extensions add roughly 50% of cost to value, not 100%. Compare the total cost of extending (including professional fees, disruption, and months of stress) against buying a property that already has the space you need.

2 Check drainage routes under the proposed footprint

Commission a CCTV drainage survey before committing to any design. Collapsed drains, build-over agreements, and sewer relocations routinely add £10,000 or more to budgets. This is the most common unbudgeted cost.

3 Investigate soil type and foundation depth

Clay soils (common across London and the South East) can require foundations 1.8 metres deep or more. This transforms your structural costs overnight. Check the British Geological Survey map for your postcode.

4 Search for previous extensions consuming your PD rights

Previous owners may have already used your permitted development quota without your knowledge. Check with your local planning authority before assuming you can build without planning permission.

5 Review title deeds for restrictive covenants

Restrictive covenants can halt projects entirely. Your solicitor should confirm there are no restrictions on building, alterations, or change of use before you spend a penny on design work.

BEFORE YOU APPOINT PROFESSIONALS

6 Check leasehold consent requirements (if applicable)

Freeholders can demand consent fees and a percentage of the value uplift your extension creates. This can amount to thousands of pounds. Discover this requirement before spending on architects, not after.

7 Apply for pre-application planning advice

Typically £200-£600 depending on your council. This reveals whether your proposal is likely to succeed and what changes would improve your chances. Far cheaper than a refused full application.

8 Write a detailed project brief before any drawings start

Define three lists: must-have, nice-to-have, and explicitly out-of-scope. Specify finishes, fixtures, electrical point locations, and heating requirements before any professional picks up a pencil.

BEFORE YOU SIGN A CONTRACT

9 Serve Party Wall notices and budget for surveyor costs

Budget £2,000-£5,000 for party wall surveyors. You pay for both sides. The process takes a minimum of two months and difficult neighbours can cause significantly longer delays.

10 Get 4-5 detailed quotes using a proper tender pack

Quotes for identical work vary by 50-100%. Fewer than four quotes means you cannot identify outliers or spot unrealistic pricing. Provide identical specification documents to every builder who quotes.

11 Specify every finish and fitting before agreeing a price

No specification means no fixed price. Every undefined detail becomes a potential "extra" during the build. If you have not specified it in writing, you will pay more for it later.

12 Choose fixed-price contract with milestone payments

Cost-plus contracts have caused documented disputes exceeding £40,000. Always tie every payment to a completed work stage. Never pay on calendar dates. Never use cost-plus for residential work.

BEFORE WORK STARTS ON SITE

13 Include a 2.5-5% retention clause in the contract

Retention gives you financial leverage to ensure all snagging items are completed properly. Without a retention clause, you lose your single strongest tool for getting defects fixed after the builder considers the job finished.

14 Set your contingency at 15-20%

Evidence from hundreds of real projects shows that 10% contingencies are consumed within the first few weeks. Budget realistically from the start, or face personal loans, credit cards, and borrowing from family.

15 Update your buildings insurance and notify your insurer

Your existing policy may be void during the construction period if you do not inform your insurer in advance. Confirm that your cover includes contractor damage, theft of materials, and public liability.

■ The Golden Rule of Extension Payment

Never get ahead on payments. The amount you have paid should never exceed the value of completed work on site. Any deposit over 10% is a warning sign. Good builders do not need your money before they start.

20-80%

typical budget overrun

2-3x

average timeline slippage

50-100%

quote variation for same work

£2k-£5k

party wall surveyor costs